What to Ask the Medicaid Agency, and What to Ask Someone Else, Now That Mom Is Approved

Fifteen questions about notices, renewals and changes, sorted by who can answer them, with room to write what they say.

You have the caseworker's phone number and a head full of questions. Some are the caseworker's to answer, and some belong to someone else.

Bring the questions written down, ask them as they are, and write the answer under each one, with the date and the name of the person who answered. This guide doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. The answers depend on Mom's situation and on your state's rules, which is why each question sits beside the kind of person who can speak to it.

The Medicaid agency or Mom's caseworker

The office that sent the approval notice. Have the notice in front of you when you call, along with any reference number printed on it.

1. What effective date do you have for Mom's eligibility, and does it match the date in the notice we received?

2. Does the notice describe anything Mom or the family needs to keep doing or keep paying after approval, and where in the notice is it?

3. When is Mom's next renewal, and what will you send us before it?

4. What might we be asked to send at renewal, so we can keep it together as we go?

5. Which changes in Mom's income, accounts, property, living arrangements, marital status or care setting do you need to hear about, how do we tell you, and where is that written down?

6. What mailing address and phone number do you have for letters about Mom, and how do we update them?

The facility's social worker or business office

If Mom is in a nursing home or another care facility.

1. Do any letters about Mom's Medicaid come to you instead of to the family, and how will we hear about them?

2. If Mom's room, unit or care setting changes, who lets the family know, and who lets the Medicaid agency know?

Your Medicaid planner

The person who goes through the approval notice with your family and looks at significant changes with you before anyone acts on them.

1. What does our family have to do now that Medicaid has approved Mom? Can you go through the approval notice, the ongoing obligations and the renewal requirements with us?

2. Here is what has changed since the application. Which of these should we be asking the Medicaid agency about?

3. Money has arrived, or may arrive, outside Mom's usual income: an inheritance, a gift, proceeds from a sale or an insurance policy. What do you need to know about it, and who should look at it before anyone does anything with it?

4. Before a major financial step involving Mom's money or property, such as a gift or a transfer, who should review it, and what should we bring?

5. If we went over all of this with you from time to time, what would you want us to bring: notices, renewal papers, records, a list of what has changed?

An elder law attorney

Legal questions belong to an attorney. If you aren't sure whether a question is a legal one, ask your Medicaid planner.

1. Are Mom's legal documents current for her situation as it is now, and what would prompt you to look at them again?

2. If a notice from the agency ever says something we don't understand or don't agree with, what would you want us to bring you?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions or tell you which one comes first. Where a letter from the Medicaid agency gives a date, go by the letter. If you aren't sure who a question belongs to, write “not sure” beside it and bring it to your Medicaid planner. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You have your questions, and you know whose each one is. The planning interview asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report, so the people you are about to ask can see where your family is starting from.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The questions about renewal letters and the address the agency has on file follow the federal renewal flyer for people with Medicaid. Medicaid.gov's help page lists the contact details for each state's Medicaid agency. The grouping by role is ours.

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS), Have Medicaid or CHIP? Get ready to renew your coverage
2. Medicaid.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Where Can People Get Help With Medicaid & CHIP?